

1. Theories on the Origin of the State

There are four widely accepted theories regarding how states were formed, though they remain speculative due to a lack of concrete evidence. All theories agree a state must have four elements: territory, population, government, and sovereignty.

- **Force Theory:**

- **Concept:** The state is developed through the use of force, where one person or a small group claims control over a population in a specific area.
- **Establishment:** The state is established once this rule is solidified, often as a result of war.
- **Example:** Adolf Hitler's control over Germany and attempted control of Europe.

- **Evolutionary Theory:**

- **Concept:** The state evolved over time, starting from a primitive family unit where one person was the leader.
- **Progression:** Over decades, the family grew into a clan, the clan became a tribe, and the state was identified when the tribe settled in a designated area.
- **Example:** Native American tribes who selected a chief to lead their family groups.

- **Divine Right Theory:**

- **Concept:** God created the state and granted individuals of royal birth the "divine right" to rule.
- **Obedience:** People obeyed the ruler because the ruler was accountable to God; disobeying the ruler was seen as disobeying God.
- **Context:** Prevalent in England and Europe during the Middle Ages.

- **Social Contract Theory:**

- **Concept:** A population in a specific area agrees to give up some power to a government to promote the well-being of all.
- **The Contract:** The state holds authority over the territory, and in exchange, the community receives services like safety and rights protection.

- **Origins:** Developed in the 17th and 18th centuries by philosophers like Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau.
- **Example:** The U.S. political system is based on this theory.

2. Key Political Thinkers (Age of Enlightenment)

During the 17th and 18th centuries (Age of Reason), thinkers questioned divine right and argued for improvement through reason, influencing the American and French Revolutions.

- **John Locke (Liberalism):**

- **Authority:** Believed government authority comes from the consent of the people, not divine right or conquest.
- **Right to Revolt:** If the government fails to uphold its contract, people have the right to revolt.
- **Influence:** His ideas on protecting God-given rights (freedom of expression/religion) and property inspired Thomas Jefferson and the U.S. Bill of Rights.

- **Jean-Jacques Rousseau (Democracy):**

- **Direct Democracy:** Believed true freedom exists only where people govern themselves directly, as representative governments can create factions.
- **Voting:** Argued citizens should vote directly on all laws to reflect the true will of the people.
- **Influence:** Inspired Thomas Paine's "The Rights of Man".

- **Adam Smith (Free Market):**

- **Role of Government:** Expanded on Locke's protection of property, arguing government should be "hands-off" in regulating markets.
- **Self-Interest:** Believed free trade allows people to pursue self-interest, which ultimately increases the wealth of the entire nation.
- **Legacy:** His concepts birthed free-market capitalism and shaped the U.S. economy.

- **Baron de Montesquieu (Balance of Power):**

- **Factions:** Concerned that in large republics, factions would run the government for private interest rather than public good.

- **Solution:** Proposed dividing government into branches where each checks the other ("ambition counteracts ambition").
- **Legacy:** Foundation of the U.S. system of checks and balances.

3. Forms of Government: Parliamentary vs. Presidential

Parliamentary System:

- **Selection:** The executive (Cabinet) is chosen by the parliament, usually from the majority political party.
- **Voters:** People only vote for members of parliament.
- **Fusion of Powers:** There is no clear separation between executive and legislative branches; executive members perform legislative duties as well.
- **Accountability:** The executive stays in power only as long as they have the "confidence" of parliament; a "vote of no confidence" can remove the government.
- **Dissolution:** The Executive leader can dissolve parliament and call for new elections.
- **Head of State:** Distinct from the Head of Government (Prime Minister/Premier); the President/Monarch is often purely ceremonial.

Presidential System:

- **Separation:** The executive branch exists and governs separately from the legislature.
- **Selection:** The President is elected in a separate election from the legislature.
- **Independence:** The legislature cannot dismiss the executive in normal circumstances, and their terms of office are not linked.
- **Cabinet:** The President appoints ministers (Secretaries) who are usually *not* members of the legislature.
- **Dual Role:** The President serves as both the chief executive and the symbolic head of government.
- **Key Distinction:** Characterized by a strict separation of powers and checks and balances.